

DELHI | Future Shock



KARAT

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Communism meets tragedy. It's not the Congress or the BJP saying so, but Prakash Karat, the CPI(M) supremo who recently confided to renowned British Marxist historian Eric Hobsbawm that his party is battered, beleaguered and besieged in West Bengal and is expected to do badly in the next Assembly elections. With Kerala expected to stick to tradition and swap power next year, the CPI(M) may be left with just tiny Tripura. Comrades in Kolkata are livid at Karat's remarks, particularly the timing of the grim forecast. Karat's prophecy comes at a time when he is fighting a section in the party which believes that is in the CPI(M)'s interest to pamper the Congress and distance it from the Trinamool. It will only help to heighten the feud between the state unit and the central leadership.

by Shafi Rahman

A LOCAL BJP MLA LED A PROTEST AGAINST AN INDUSTRIAL PLANT IN MODI'S GUJARAT.

GUJARAT | Acquisition Row

It isn't just Marxist-ruled West Bengal that faces trouble over land acquisition. Even Narendra Modi's Vibrant Gujarat is facing problems. A proposal by a big industrial house to build a two-million tonne capacity cement plant is running into stiff opposition from local farmers. Ironically, the agitation is led by BJP MLA Kanu Kalsaria in Mahuva Taluka of Bhavnagar district, who organised a 20-km padyatra last year. Protesters were prevented from marching to Gandhinagar last week. Modi met Kalsaria and told him, "I wish God gives you wisdom." But Kalsaria isn't yielding.

by Uday Mahurkar

KOLKATA | Death Pool

Elephants dying on rail tracks, falling numbers of tigers and rhinos, marmosets stolen from a zoo, and now 18 monkeys found dead in the Bengdubi army unit swimming pool in North Bengal. This state forest department has some explaining to do, but the answers aren't really coming. On the monkey deaths, Chief Conservator of Forests Atanu Raha says: "It's definitely not mass drowning." Foul play or just simian antics gone horribly wrong, the department needs to pull up its socks.

by Abhijit Dasgupta

VIOLENT PROTESTS OVER A TASLIMA NASREEN ARTICLE LEAVE TWO DEAD.

BANGALORE | Printer's Devil

An old article by exiled Bangladeshi author Taslima Nasreen denouncing the purdah system published in a Kannada daily on February 28 provoked protests from sections of the Muslim community, leaving two dead in Shimoga. In a backlash, Hindu cultural group Sri Rama Sene has called for a Hassan bandh on March 2 even as Chief Minister B.S. Yeddyurappa condemned the article. For Nasreen, who is currently in New York, this may well be another hurdle in her return to India, despite her claiming that she never wrote any article for the newspaper and it was a "deliberate attempt to malign" her and "misuse" her writings to create disturbance in society. For the state Government though, it will only add to the Opposition's claim that all is not well on the communal front under Yeddyurappa's dispensation.

by Stephen David



RIOTING IN SHIMOGA

BK RAMESH